

What is a situational picture?

The term, its origin – and six examples from hospital, fire brigade, navigation and corporate IT

Version 1.0 · As of 2026-08-19 · Audience: readers without a military background – decision-makers, portfolio and programme leads, architects, controllers. The document assumes nothing beyond the experience of having sat through a status meeting at least once.

Companion memorandum to the situational-picture series: the explanation of the term that all the main memoranda presuppose.

About this document: Curated, conceived and editorially owned by **Robert Seebauer**; researched and produced with the support of **Claude** (Anthropic – model **Claude Fable 5**, via Claude Code). This companion memorandum was written in response to a query that came back after the series was published: *“What exactly do you mean by ‘situational picture’?”* The main memoranda ([Team of Teams & Staff Training](#), [Enterprise Architecture & Solution Situational Picture](#), [AI and the Situational Picture](#)) use the term on every page – here it is explained, delimited and shown in examples that require no uniform. Earlier editions: [release archive](#) [denkschriften/<date>](#).

Transparency notice: This memorandum was produced with the support of an AI system (Claude, Anthropic – model Claude Fable 5, via Claude Code): drafting, research preparation, typesetting and chart code. All content was substantively reviewed, edited and approved by Robert Seebauer, who holds editorial responsibility.

Executive Summary

What is this about? A term that comes up constantly in this series and is rarely used outside staffs, control rooms and ships' bridges: the **situational picture**. Those who never served hear the military in it; those who work in a large corporation think of a status report or a dashboard. Both lead astray. A situational picture is something more precise – and more everyday – than either.

The short answer: A situational picture is the **shared, honest answer to three questions** – *Where do we stand? What has changed? What follows from it?* – prepared so that someone can then **decide**. The situational picture is not the numbers but the answer. What makes it good is not completeness but honesty about what one knows, what one does not, and how certain one is.

THE SINGLE MOST IMPORTANT SENTENCE IN THIS DOCUMENT

A situational picture is not a collection of numbers but the shared, honest answer to three questions – where do we stand, what has changed, what follows from it – prepared so that someone can decide.

The three core messages of this companion memorandum:

- 1 The situational picture is older and more civilian than its reputation.** Fire-brigade incident commands lead with a situation map, hospitals hand over patients using the SBAR scheme, every navigator begins with the ship's position. The term comes from military command doctrine – the practice behind it is found wherever people have to decide together under uncertainty (Part A, Part C).
- 2 Six characteristics separate a situational picture from a status report.** It answers the three questions; it is shared (one truth for everyone); it is honest (confidence attached to every number, “we don't know” is an admissible statement); it is decision-oriented (every piece of information answers a leadership question); it is aggregated and current; and it has a host – the ritual in which it is discussed. If one of them is missing, it is not a situational picture but reporting (Part A.3).

- 3 You can start within a week.** One page, four fields, three questions, a fixed appointment – Part D shows the template. The series' software (SituationReport) automates exactly this page; the memoranda explain what belongs on it and who reads it.

Part A – What a situational picture is – and what it is not

A.1 Origin of the term: situation, situational picture, assessment of the situation

In military command doctrine, the **situation** (German *Lage*) is the totality of all circumstances that matter for the accomplishment of a mission: one's own situation (forces, condition, supply), the situation of the adversary or – in civilian terms – of the environment, the terrain, the time, the civilian population. The **situational picture** (*Lagebild*) is the *prepared representation* of this situation: what is known, what is assumed, what is not known – and how certain one is about all of it. The **assessment of the situation** (*Lagebeurteilung*) is the thinking about it: *What does this mean for my mission, what options do I have, which one do I choose?* The **situation briefing** (*Lagevortrag*) is the oral form delivered to the decision-maker; **situation centre** or **situation service** (*Lagezentrum, Lagedienst*) is the name of the organisation that maintains the picture continuously.

This distinction is the key to the whole term: **The situational picture is not the decision and not the plan – it is the precondition for both.** That is why the series' guiding sentence reads "First the situational picture, then the plan": if you do not know where you stand, you need not tell anyone where to march.

In English-language doctrine the same concept appears as *situational awareness* (the individual's knowledge of the situation), *common operational picture* (the shared picture, identical for everyone) and *situation report*, *SITREP* for short (the report that carries it) – which is where the name of this series' software comes from.

A.2 Why the word is missing in the corporation – and what is there instead

Corporations have status reports, dashboards, KPI reports, traffic lights. All four contain information about the situation. None of them is automatically a situational picture. The difference lies not in the data but in **purpose and attitude**:

	Status report	Dashboard / KPI report	Situational picture
Purpose	Accountability: "We did what we were supposed to do"	Observation: "This is what the numbers look like"	Decision: "This is where we stand – and this is what follows"
Perspective	The reporter (upwards)	The system (neutral)	The decision-maker (downwards: their questions first)
Handling of uncertainty	Avoid (traffic light green)	Hide (number without a range)	Declare (confidence attached to every number, "we don't know")
Bad news	Career risk	Not evaluated	First – and praised
Does what is missing stand out?	No	No	Yes: an open leadership question without an answer is a finding
Host	The report itself	The screen	The ritual (situation briefing, sync, O&I)

A status report *can* become a situational picture – if it answers the decision-maker's questions instead of the reporter's, declares its uncertainty instead of hiding it, and is read together regularly instead of being filed. That is exactly what the whole series is about.

A.3 Six characteristics of a situational picture (the checklist)

1 It answers the three questions.

Where do we stand? What has changed? What follows from it? Whoever cannot answer the second question has a snapshot, not a situational picture – a situational picture is *kept up to date*. Whoever does not answer the third delivers data, not an assessment.

2 It is shared.

One truth for everyone instead of twenty silo reports, each with its own definition of “done”. McChrystal's term for this is *shared consciousness*: everyone knows the whole picture, not just their own slice (Team-of-Teams memorandum, Part A).

3 It is honest.

Confidence belongs to the number (EA principle 4): “lead time 50 days on average, spread 40–60, within the corridor in 85% of cases” is a situational picture; “50 days” is an assertion. “We don't know” is an admissible – often the most important – statement. Bad news goes at the top.

4 It is decision-oriented.

Every piece of information answers a question that someone actually *has*. The yardstick is the value of information (Hubbard): which information would change a decision? Everything else is decoration – and decoration hides the monsters in the dark (Memorandum 0: the streetlight effect).

5 It is aggregated and current.

It shows teams and initiatives, not individuals (AI memorandum, principle 6) – and it arrives in rhythm, not in perfection: a current, incomplete picture beats a complete one from last quarter.

6 It has a host.

Without a fixed ritual – the appointment at which it is read together, questioned and translated into decisions – every situational picture is a dashboard nobody looks at. It is not the tool that creates the situational picture but the ritual and the trained people around it (the Team-of-Teams single sentence).

RULE OF THUMB

If you are holding a document and cannot say *which decision* it prepares today, *what has changed since last time* and *how certain* its most important number is – then you are holding a report. Not a situational picture.

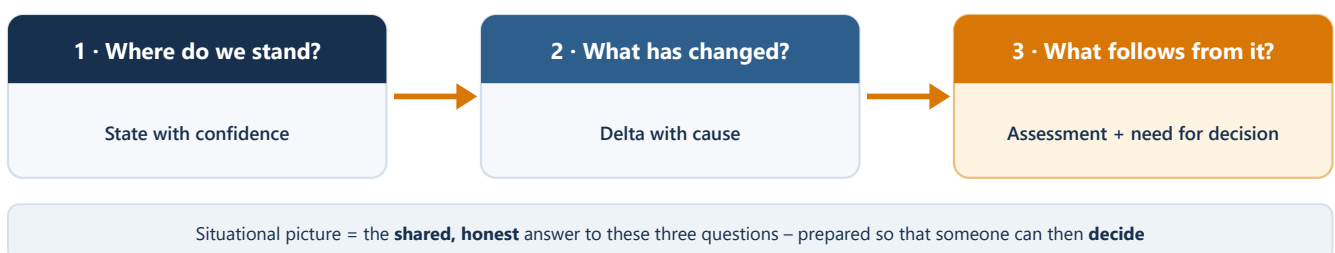


Fig. 1 – The three questions of a situational picture and their answer forms: state with confidence, delta with cause, assessment and need for decision. The third question is the one almost always missing from corporate reports.

Part B – The situational picture in the command process

B.1 The control loop that all command doctrines share

Whether general staff, fire brigade or hospital: leading under uncertainty follows the same loop everywhere. The German fire-service regulation FwDV 100 “Command and Control in Operations” calls it the **command process** and describes it as a control loop of **establishing the situation** (reconnaissance and control), **planning** (assessment of the situation and decision) and **issuing orders** – which leads back into establishing the situation, because every order changes the situation. Military command doctrine knows the same steps as establishing the situation → assessment of the situation → decision → plan → order → control; US doctrine calls the loop the *operations process* (plan, prepare, execute, assess continuously) and places *situational understanding* at its start.

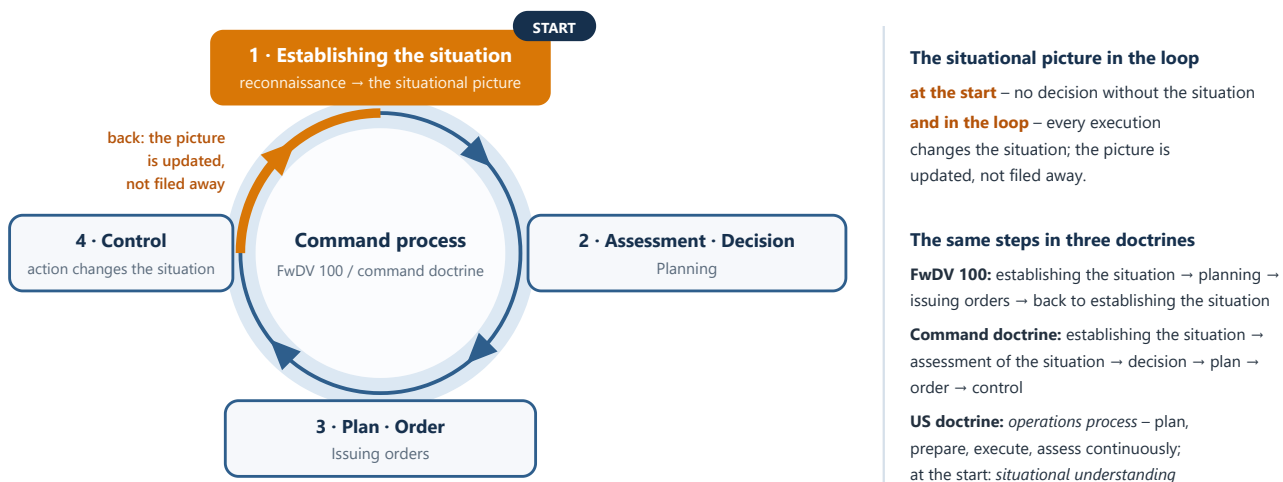


Fig. 2 – The command process as a control loop (FwDV 100 / military command doctrine, simplified): the situational picture stands at the start – and is updated within the loop, because every execution changes the situation.

For us, the nomenclature matters less than the place of the situational picture within it: **at the start** (no decision without the situation) **and in the loop** (every execution changes the situation – the picture is updated, not filed away). Whoever sets portfolio goals and announces plans without first establishing the situation has entered the loop at the wrong point.

B.2 The three questions and their answer forms

Question	Answer form in the situational picture	Example (portfolio)
Where do we stand?	State with confidence	“Release 3.2: 62% probability for 30 September (Monte Carlo, 10,000 runs, data since PI 3)”
What has changed?	Delta since the last picture, with cause	“Lead time P85 from 62 to 71 days – cause: WIP from 24 to 34 features”
What follows from it?	Assessment + need for decision	“Without a WIP cap the release probability keeps falling; to decide today: cap at 26 or scope cut”

The third row is the one almost always missing from corporate reports – and the one that makes the difference between a situational picture and a slide.

B.3 Who reads the situational picture? Two readings, one picture

A good situational picture is read by two groups who need different things and must nevertheless see the same: the **leadership** wants assessment, trend and need for decision on one page; the **specialist staff** wants the numbers behind it, in order to check and explain them. The EA memorandum calls this “*Two readings, one picture*” (principle 3): the same facts, prepared differently – but never different facts. Where leadership and specialist staff have different numbers, there is no situational picture but two narratives.

Part C – Six examples

C.1 The shift handover in the hospital: SBAR

On a ward the nurses change shifts; in thirty seconds per patient the next shift has to know where things stand. Worldwide, a scheme has established itself for this that came from the US Navy into the clinic and is today recommended by the WHO and the Joint Commission: **SBAR** – *Situation* (what is going on), *Background* (what the history is), *Assessment* (what I think it means), *Recommendation* (what I propose). That is a situational picture in miniature: state, context, assessment, conclusion – in a fixed order, so that nothing is forgotten and the recipient knows immediately where the assessment begins and the facts end. Anyone who has ever read a corporate status report in which facts, opinions and wishes flow indistinguishably into one another understands the value of these four letters.

Transfer: Every line of a portfolio situational picture can take SBAR – Situation (number with confidence), Background (delta and cause), Assessment (what it means), Recommendation (proposed decision).

C.2 The fire brigade's incident command: the situation map

A house fire, twelve vehicles, three local fire brigades. The incident commander does not lead by instructing every crew personally – he cannot be everywhere at once. He leads by **leading a situational picture**: the situation map shows fire spread, deployed forces, hazards, water supply, operational sectors. Every report from the scene updates the picture; every decision is taken *at the picture*; whoever joins is briefed *at the picture*. The regulation FwDV 100 turns this into a system: command organisation, command process, command resources – and the situation map is the central command resource.

Three things about this are instructive for portfolios. First: the picture is **shared** – sector commanders, control room and incident commander see the same thing. Second: it is **kept up to date** – minute by minute, not at month-end. Third: it shows **forces and sectors**, not individuals – the aggregate level of command. A portfolio with 14 ARTs, 40 products and 2,400 people is no smaller than a major fire; it is just usually run without a situation map.

C.3 The bridge: position, course, destination

The oldest situational-picture profession is the navigator's. Before anyone sets a course, the question is: *Where are we?* Then: *Where do we want to go, what lies in between – wind, current, shoals – and how certain is our position?* The logbook is the delta: what has changed since the last entry? A navigator who knows his position “roughly” and does not say so endangers the ship more than one who honestly writes “position uncertain, ± 2 nautical miles” in the log – because with the second statement the bridge can plan (safety margin, bearing), with the first it cannot.

Transfer: The sentence from Memorandum 0 – “An estimation accuracy of 50% is neither good nor bad; *not knowing it is bad*” – is navigator's wisdom.

C.4 The portfolio situational picture of a solution: one page

This is what the transfer into corporate IT looks like – a fictitious solution “Customer Portal” with six ARTs, as of one calendar week, a single page (the numbers are invented, the structure is that of this series' software):

Flow – is the work flowing?

Feature lead time P50 38 days / P85 71 days (+9 days since PI start; 240 data points). WIP 34 features against a sustainable capacity of ~24 (**red**). Forecast release 3.2 by 30 September: **62%** (Monte Carlo, 10,000 runs; previous month 78%).

Quality – what comes out the other end?

3 open P1 incidents (previous month 1). NFR runway payments **yellow** (load test outstanding). Change failure rate 9% (stable).

Value – is it worth it?

2 of 5 epics without a quantified cost of delay. Capacity share maintenance/compliance 40% (target ≤ 30%).

Dependencies – how does it all hang together?

3 critical dependencies on ART Core Banking, 1 of them not ROAMed (date open). Skills gap cloud security: 2 roles unfilled.

What has changed?

WIP +10, P85 +9 days, release probability –16 points – the three are connected.

What follows / to decide today:

(1) WIP cap 26 or scope cut for release 3.2; (2) escalation of the open Core Banking dependency; (3) CoD quantification of the two epics by the next sync.

What we do not know:

Impact of the load test on the release date – result in week 35.

Fig. 3 – The portfolio situational picture of a solution on one page: four fields, three questions, confidence attached to the numbers, one declared knowledge gap (fictitious numbers; structure of the SituationReport software).

Count them: the three questions (state, delta, conclusion), confidence attached to the numbers, bad news at the top, no individuals, one open knowledge gap declared, three concrete decisions. That is a situational picture. The same numbers as forty dashboard tiles would not be.

C.5 The delta briefing: only what has changed

The strongest form of the second question is an artefact of its own: the **delta briefing** – *since the last sync, the following has changed*, five lines, each with cause and assessment. It is what McChrystal's daily O&I briefing delivered at its core (Team-of-Teams memorandum) and what Gregor Hohpe calls the “first derivative” of architecture: the interesting information is not the state but its rate of change. For the series' software, the delta briefing is the first AI-supported pilot (AI memorandum, phase D2) – precisely because it relieves the leadership of the search for what is new and directs attention to where a decision is needed.

C.6 Three counter-examples – and why they are not situational pictures

1

The traffic-light slide.

Twelve initiatives, twelve green dots, until the initiative jumps to red two weeks before the deadline (“watermelon”: green outside, red inside). Not a situational picture, because no confidence, no delta, no honesty – the traffic light measures the reporter's courage, not the situation.

2

The spaghetti slide.

McChrystal's famous diagram of Afghan insurgency dynamics: hundreds of nodes and arrows, nothing to be made out – “*When we understand that slide, we'll have won the war*” (Memorandum 0). Not a situational picture, because it answers no question and prepares no decision – it is completeness without assessment.

3

The KPI graveyard.

Number of trained Scrum Masters, lines of code, number of meetings. Not a situational picture, because none of these numbers would change a leadership decision – the streetlight instead of the search area.

All three lack the same thing: the third question. They show something, but they do not say what follows from it.

Part D – How to start: the first situational-picture page in one week – and the cadence thereafter

1 Day 1 – Collect the decision-maker's questions.

Not: "What data do we have?", but: "Which three decisions are due in the next eight weeks – and which information would change them?" (Hubbard's question). That is the blueprint of the page.

2 Days 2–3 – Fill four fields.

Flow · Quality · Value · Dependencies (Memorandum 0) – two or three statements each, every one with confidence ("high/medium/low" is enough at the start) and delta to the last known state. What is not known is declared as a line of its own, not omitted.

3 Day 4 – Write the third question.

For every statement: What follows from it? What is to be decided today? If nothing follows, strike it.

4 Day 5 – Appoint the host: the first edition.

A fixed appointment in a **two-week cadence**, 45 minutes, the page is the only slide, the chief moderates, bad news gets praised (Team-of-Teams memorandum, "O&I light"). The first edition takes place on day 5. Without this appointment the page is a report.

5 Week 3 – The second edition: update, don't rewrite.

It begins with the delta – what has changed since the first edition? Every further edition follows in the same cadence (weeks 5, 7, 9 ...).

6 Week 5 – The third edition: clear out.

After three editions it becomes apparent which lines have never triggered a decision – they go. What remains is the situational picture this leadership really needs.

What the software contributes: SituationReport generates exactly this page from flow data – lead times with spreads, throughput, WIP, Monte Carlo forecasts with confidence interval, aggregated across teams and solutions, with delta to the previous period. It supplies number and confidence; the third question – *what follows from it* – is answered by the staff, in the ritual. That is not a weakness of the tool but the division of labour the whole series calls for.

Connectivity to the series

- **Memorandum 0** supplies the four fields and the sentence with which everything began: First the situational picture, then the plan.
- **Team of Teams & Staff Training** supplies the host (the ritual), the coupling with decentralised decision authority – and the training of those who create and read situational pictures.
- **Enterprise Architecture & Solution Situational Picture** supplies the content beyond the flow metrics (capabilities, debt, NFR, dependencies) and the five situational-picture principles – among them "Confidence belongs to the number" and "Two readings, one picture".
- **AI and the Situational Picture** supplies the situation service: how the picture is created and provided with AI support – with AI as a staff member, not as a commander.
- **Four Architecture Thought Leaders** supply the civilian corroborating witnesses for the fact that deciding under uncertainty with a shared language is leadership work.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Situation (<i>Lage</i>)	Totality of the circumstances that matter for the accomplishment of a mission (own forces, environment, terrain, time)
Situational picture (<i>Lagebild</i>)	Prepared, shared representation of the situation – what is known, what is not, how certain; basis of the assessment
Assessment of the situation (<i>Lagebeurteilung</i>)	Thinking about the situation: what it means for the mission, which options there are, which one is chosen
Situation briefing (<i>Lagevortrag</i>)	Oral presentation of the situational picture to the decision-maker (civilian: the portfolio sync, the O&I briefing)
Situation service / situation centre (<i>Lagedienst / Lagezentrum</i>)	Organisation that continuously creates and provides the situational picture (AI memorandum: “from report to situation service”)
Command process (<i>Führungsvorgang</i>)	Control loop of command. FwDV 100: establishing the situation (reconnaissance <i>and</i> control) → planning (assessment, decision) → issuing orders – and again from the start. Military command doctrine: establishing the situation → assessment of the situation → decision → plan → order → control
Situational awareness	Individual knowledge and understanding of the situation
Common operational picture (COP)	The shared, identical situational picture for everyone involved – McChrystal's shared consciousness
Situation report (SITREP)	The report that carries a situational picture; namesake of the software
Delta briefing	Form of situational picture that shows only what has changed since the last picture – with cause and assessment
Mission command (Auftragstaktik)	Leading with objective and intent instead of individual instructions – presupposes a shared situational picture (otherwise chaos)
Confidence	Declared certainty of a statement (spread, probability, data basis) – belongs to every number in the situational picture
SBAR	Situation – Background – Assessment – Recommendation: handover scheme from the clinic, a situational picture in miniature

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Internal references: Memorandum 0 (four fields, streetlight effect, estimation accuracy) · Team of Teams & Staff Training (shared consciousness, O&I, ritual) · Enterprise Architecture & Solution Situational Picture (five situational-picture principles) · AI and the Situational Picture (situation service, delta briefing, principle 6) · SituationReport software – all in the [online overview of the series](#).

Version history

Version	Date	Changes
1.0	2026-08-19	First edition, written in response to the query “What do you mean by situational picture?” that came back after the series was published: term and origin (situation, situational picture, assessment of the situation, situation briefing, situation service), delimitation from status report/dashboard/KPI report, six characteristics, command process (FwDV 100, military command doctrine, ADP 5-0), three questions with answer forms, two readings, six examples (SBAR, fire-brigade situation map, navigation, portfolio situational picture of a solution, delta briefing, three counter-examples), start guide “one page in one week”, glossary. Transparency notice per the series standard.

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